

HARVEST

* Blue denotes PPT slide

* Brown – Instructions to technician

TEXT: Deuteronomy 26:1-11 (NKJV)

“And it shall be, when you come into the land which the Lord your God is giving you as an inheritance, and you possess it and dwell in it, 2 that you shall take some of the first of all the produce of the ground, which you shall bring from your land that the Lord your God is giving you, and put it in a basket and go to the place where the Lord your God chooses to make His name abide. 3 And you shall go to the one who is priest in those days, and say to him, ‘I declare today to the Lord your God that I have come to the country which the Lord swore to our fathers to give us.’ 4 “Then the priest shall take the basket out of your hand and set it down before the altar of the Lord your God. 5 And you shall answer

and say before the Lord your God: ‘My father was a Syrian, about to perish, and he went down to Egypt and dwelt there, few in number; and there he became a nation, great, mighty, and populous. 6 But the Egyptians mistreated us, afflicted us, and laid hard bondage on us. 7 Then we cried out to the Lord God of our fathers, and the Lord heard our voice and looked on our affliction and our labor and our oppression. 8 So the Lord brought us out of Egypt with a mighty hand and with an outstretched arm, with great terror and with signs and wonders. 9 He has brought us to this place and has given us this land, “a land flowing with milk and honey”; 10 and now, behold, I have brought the firstfruits of the land which you, O Lord, have given me.’ “Then you shall set it before the Lord your God, and worship before the Lord your God. 11 So you shall rejoice in every good thing which the Lord your God has given to you and your house,

you and the Levite and the stranger who is among you.”

INTRO: The Harvest Offering mentioned in Deuteronomy 26 was to take place at the occasion of the first harvest after entering into the Promised Land. (The fall is harvest time)

Notice, in verse one the Moses say's,
“When (Not if) you come into the land.”

The Harvest offering was to be given in remembrance of where they had come from and in celebration of where God had brought them.

Where they had come from:

- Theirs Fathers were *“Syrian”* = Nomad's with no permanent home, permanent land or stability. *“About to perish, few in number.”*

- They went to “***Egypt***” = The place of oppression, bondage and frustration. “***Mistreated us; afflicted us; laid hard bondage on us.***” But notice, in spite of this they became a great nation! “***Great, mighty and populous.***” (Manasseh = Forgetfulness (Manasseh was the first son of Joseph) Ephraim = Fruitfulness (Ephraim was the second son of Joseph) – “***The Lord made me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.***”)
- They cried out to “***The Lord***” = The Lord brought them out with “***A mighty hand; an outstretched arm; great terror; signs and wonders.***”
- The Lord was going to bring them into “***This Land***” = Into a place of inheritance, permanence and stability. A place “***Flowing with milk and honey.***”

The command of Moses was for the Israelites to bring a “***Harvest offering***” to

the Lord, of the first harvest in Canaan. The offering being referred to here; was to be an extra special, exceptional offering. The idea here is that their offering would enact the blessing of God upon all their other harvests in Canaan!

The Lord had brought them from being lost and oppressed into the inheritance of Christ and His victory and blessing. The fact is that in one place in Scripture they were referred to as “*Not a people.*”

The same is true with us! If it were not for the Lord...

Thanking God for our harvest is right and wise and it keeps us properly focused and centered in His divine favor. It is right because God is our source.

It is wise because it demonstrates humility, and that ensures God's grace and favor toward us. It is an act of recognition that we could not have accomplished these things on our own!

It keeps us properly focused – We do not become prideful and therefore avoids God's resistance.

Deuteronomy 28:1-2 (NIV) *“If you fully obey the Lord your God and carefully follow all His commands I give you today, the Lord your God will set you high above all the nations on earth. All these blessings will come upon you and accompany you if you will obey the Lord your God.”*

The wise man thanks God for his harvest and continues forward in His grace and blessing. How are we to thank God? With

- Confession...

- Giving...
- Joyful worship...

The land the Lord and Moses spoke to the Israelites about is called the “*Promised Land*.” It is called the “*Promised Land*” because God had promised it to their ancestors! He was also promising it to them! Finally, He was promising it to their descendants!

Notice God’s actions in verse one: (Place on screen one at a time)

- He called them...
- He made promises to them...
- He brought deliverance...
- He provided an inheritance for them...
- He blessed the soil to bring forth the harvest...

This is important because it shows us that what God has given us – He has **PLANNED** to give us. He is thoughtful and purposeful and has our best interests at heart!

What God has set aside to give – No one can take away! No one can rob God of it – Only we can rob ourselves of it!

ILLUSTRATION:

Possessing this promise is like two partners dancing. One leads and the other follows in step and harmony, with the movements of the leader. God:

- Makes the date...
- Arranges the music...
- Set's the dance floor in order...
- Reaches out His hand to take us to the floor...
- Guides us as we glide across the floor into our promise...

CONCLUSION:

What are we required to do in order to step into the promise of God and reap a maximum harvest? (Place on the screen one at a time)

- Act upon the promise...
- Take hold of the possession...
- Bring an offering of the first-fruit of our harvest...
- Make confession before the Lord...
- Rejoice in worship for all God has done...

We have sought the Lord these past weeks and have prepared a Harvest Offering to present before the Lord.

We are about to bring our offering to the altar to present it before the Lord.

We are about to make confession together giving thanks to God for His salvation and blessings.

We are about to rejoice and sing praises to God for His goodness!

OFFERING PROCEDURE

- Appropriate offering containers should be pre-placed at the altar area. [Dt. 26:2]
– “*Baskets*”
- The congregants should be invited as a group to bring forward their offering and present it at the altar, placing it in the “*baskets*” before the pastoral staff & church leaders. [Dt. 26:2]
- The pastor shall take a representative portion of the offering and raise it to the Lord.
- The pastor shall call upon the members to raise their hands to the Lord and then

shall lead them in the following confession.

PRAYER OF CONFESSION (Make sure this is on the screen so the congregation can join in reciting the prayer with the pastor)

- I was once lost and estranged from God having no spiritual life.
- I lacked direction and divine purpose.
- I lived only for myself and my own pleasures.
- I placed my values on the temporary things of this world.
- I wandered about seeking peace and stability but could not find it.
- I walked in spiritual darkness and ignorance.
- Demonic agents blinded my mind and held sway in my thoughts, tempting me and influencing me to commit sin.

- I experienced oppression and mistreatment at the hand of the enemy.
- I found myself in bondage to habits, negative attitudes, fear and worry bringing harm to my spirit, body and relationships.
- But God sent His Son, Jesus Christ into this world to teach me, rescue me and restore me.
- He shined the light of His glorious gospel into my heart.
- He responded to my cries for mercy and help by stretching forth His hand to save me.
- He gave life to my spirit.
- He smote my oppressors, revoked their claims and broke their chains.
- He placed me into His kingdom and authority.
- He became my Father and brought me into His family.

- He committed to me the great and precious promises of His Word.
- He filled me with His Holy Spirit.
- He called me into His service giving me meaning and purpose.
- He blessed the work of my hands.
- He brought peace to my heart, strength to my arms and direction to my feet.
- He brought order to my house and peace to my family.

I bring this offering today:

- In remembrance of where He has brought me from.
- In celebration of where He has brought me to.
- In thanks for all He has given me.

As my sacrifice for all He is, all He has done and all He is going to do:

- I declare the power of the seed I have sown.
- I declare that the enemy will be powerless to kill or diminish its effectiveness.
- I release YOU to rebuke the devourer for my sake.
- I declare that both the seed and the harvest will produce maximum impact.
- I declare that my family and I will have more than enough because of the harvest.
- I declare that the Kingdom of God and CT church will be blessed as a result of my harvest.
- In Jesus' name – Amen

Encouragement to all – The presiding pastor shall say:

Some of you have experienced all that we have confessed today. Others of you are still

fighting forward, but be of good cheer, for you are in Jesus Christ and He has overcome the world! [John 16:33]

Your victory is accomplished. Your inheritance is secure. Possess God's promises by faith. Celebrate the completed work of the cross! Determine to obey God and realize your destiny!

Song of Celebration

(At the close of the confession and encouragement the presiding pastor or designated worship leader should lead the congregation in an appropriate song of rejoicing and thanksgiving.)